

Part 1

Part 1: Planning

Student Level: Pre-Intermediate

Aim: For students to understand when and how to describe two past events with one interrupting the other.

Target Language: Past continuous for two past events, one interrupting the other e.g., "I was having a shower, when the phone rang."

Time: 60 minutes

Assumptions: Students will be familiar with the past simple ("I answered", "she went", etc.).

Possible Problems: Students may confuse the past continuous with the past simple and struggle to understand how to combine the 2 tenses in one sentence. To encourage students to discover the meaning, think about asking students to compare this tense with one they already know and could confuse the meaning with this one. You can also use a timeline here.

Part 2

Part 2: Delivery

1. Lead-in (Teacher-Student interaction, 5 minutes)

Hand out pictures representing different actions to each student e.g. “raining”, “calling”, “walking”, “playing”, “working”, etc.
Have them identify each one, and put them up on the board.

2. Presentation (Teacher-Student interaction, 18 minutes)

Write two sentences on the board: “I was walking outside, when the rain started.” and “I walked outside.” Ask the students in pairs to discuss what the difference / similarities are between these two sentences in meaning and form.

After eliciting differences, review the differences and what the past continuous interrupted means: talking about a past action that happens until it is interrupted by another action. Write the sentence structure on the board, drill this a few times to practice the pronunciation / intonation and elicit and highlight form: “was” + present participle, then subject + past participle. Ask students to mark where it goes on a timeline including other tenses students have learned so far, just to double check they understand meaning.

Then, ask three concept check questions for the example sentence: “I was walking outside, when the rain started.”: “Were you walking outside?”, “Did it start raining before you started walking?”, “Are you still walking outside after the rain started?”

3. Practice (Pair Work, 17 minutes)

In pairs, students do a worksheet on have / has + when with sentence completion. Correct as a class.

4. Production (Teacher-Student interaction, 20 minutes)

Chain story: start with a particular time, ask one student a question, e.g. “What were you doing when the clock struck 2pm?” and allow for fantastic answers – “I was saving the city when the clock struck 2pm.”, then increment the time and move onto the next student, “What were you doing when the clock struck 3pm?”, etc. until all students have taken a turn and the chain story is complete.

5. Homework (15 minutes)

Ask students to watch videos / documentaries (e.g. animal videos) and write down at least three observations using the past continuous interrupted tense.